

film reviews

Nothing Striking

DHAN DHANA DHAN GOAL

Director: Vivek Agnihotri
Starring: John Abraham, Arshad Warsi, Boman Irani and Bipasha Basu

Goal follows the sports film formula to the last cliché—so we have a burnt out coach who must redeem himself for a past mistake; the ultimate loser team (this one hasn't won a single football match in 25 years); long sequences of the team rebuilding itself; and finally a grand, soaring finale in which, of course, the underdogs become top dogs. Some sequences, especially the finale, are well-crafted and the leading men are perfectly cast—Warsi does a fine job as the team's hapless captain and



John Abraham plays striker Abraham, with smirk and hot-bod in place, works well as the self-centred striker Sunny. The trouble is that director Agnihotri is never quite sure of the tone of the film. So *Goal* aspires to a gritty feel of London's South Asian culture but some of the characters are pure comic book—Dalip Tahil playing a scheming sportscaster

declares: "Girls love footballers, *woh testosterone, woh pasine ki khushboo!*" The reverse racism of the film—all the Brits are uniformly nasty—would also be offensive if it was not so unsophisticated.

Eventually, *Goal* is too simplistic to be memorable, but it is intermittently engaging.

by Anupama Chopra

Soulless Wonder

ELIZABETH: THE GOLDEN AGE

Director: Shekhar Kapur
Starring: Cate Blanchett, Geoffrey Rush, Clive Owen

Nine years ago, Shekhar Kapur made the propulsive, historical epic *Elizabeth*. It had enough top angle shots to give you vertigo but it also had the sweep, drama and performances (Blanchett, Rush, Joseph Fiennes, John Gielgud, Richard Attenborough, and even a pre-Bond Daniel Craig) to keep you spellbound. What happens in the sequel is curious. The same team of producer, writer, director and lead actors have reunited, but working with a bigger budget on one of history's most



Blanchett is the Virgin Queen fascinating periods, they've created a superbly soulless film. The second *Elizabeth* has the 'virgin queen' battling Catholic fundamentalism, the Spanish Armada and her own tempestuous feelings for the dashing explorer Sir Walter Raleigh. The screenplay veers between romance and statecraft, doing justice to neither

and climaxes in a sea battle, in which, Raleigh (having a Jack Sparrow moment) saves England. It has great pomp and splendour, but the visual dazzle can't compensate for the underwriting. What endures is Blanchett's performance. She is, at once, frighteningly manipulative and tragically vulnerable. Watch this for her. by Anupama Chopra

recommendations

Classic Renditions

KOLKATA ITC Sangeet Sammelan brings together the best of performing musicians.



This year, the ITC award will be presented to rudra veena maestro

Ustad Asad Khan Ustad Asad Ali Khan, who will be playing on December 1, along with other artistes, including child prodigy Yashwant Vaishnav (tabla) and Vidhyadhar Vyas (vocal). On December 2, Purbayan Chatterjee (sitar), Jayashree R. Patnekar (vocal), Gwalior gharana's voice, L.K. Pandit, and the mother-daughter duo, N. Rajam and Sangeeta Shankar (violin) will perform.



DELHI Sufis come alive at *Ruhaniyat*—the sufi and mystic music

Latif Bolat festival on December 8, featuring fakirs, monks, sufi qawwals, Bauls, shabad singers, and Kabir panthis from across India and other countries like Iran, Morocco, Senegal, Egypt, Turkey and Syria. Organised by Banyan Tree Events at The Garden of Five Senses, the festival travels to Kolkata on December 15 and Bangalore on January 8. Experience the power of Sufiana kalam.

by S. Sahaya Ranjit